

and bake for 15 minutes). Serve with bread and salad.

4. Breakfast or brunch

Breakfast/brunch servings can be smaller and lighter. Serve bagels or egg and sausage casserole with orange juice and coffee.

5. Afternoon tea

You may need to spring for a teakettle or you can use the microwave to boil water (beverage setting). Select specialty tea at your favorite grocer. Have sweetener (honey or sugar), milk, and lemon on hand. Serve with a few treats such as your favorite jam and slightly softened cream cheese with specialty crackers or goodies from your favorite bakery.

6. Dessert party

Bake your favorite desserts, which usually can be made days to weeks (if you freeze desserts) ahead of time so that getting ready for the party is a snap. If it's warm outside, you can serve ice cream with a variety of toppings in the backyard or on the front porch. Bonus: You won't have to clean up much inside.

7. Limit liquids

A chef friend has taught me to limit choices and I think this concept is applicable to food *and* beverages. Buying every combination of soft drinks (regular, sugar-free/cafeine-free, cafeine-free-only, etc.) can put a huge dent in your budget, so you may opt to serve lemonade or hot Russian tea, depending on the season. Add a pitcher of water and you'll easily accommodate many guests' beverage of preference.

8. Time limit

Parties don't have to last hours. You can schedule a quickie before or after a big event, such as dessert after a holiday show or hot chocolate after an evening of sledding or Christmas caroling. People won't arrive expecting a large food spread.

9. Require RSVPs

One of the biggest expenses associated with a party is the extra food and drink for the guests *who might show up*. Knowing how many people will be attending (and not having to guess at many more showing up the day of the event, or calling at the last minute) helps you to buy and prepare the right amounts.